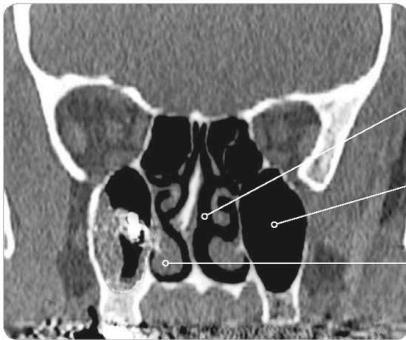


NASAL CYCLE

For many, each nostril takes turns dominating air flow (in .5- to 4-hour shifts). This is called the nasal cycle. You probably notice this more when you are congested. Openness indicates local vasoconstriction and the swollenness indicates vasodilation. Observe this cycle naturally or try purposefully covering one nostril for a desired effect (see panel right).



Open nasal passage
Maxillary sinus
Engorged nasal tissue

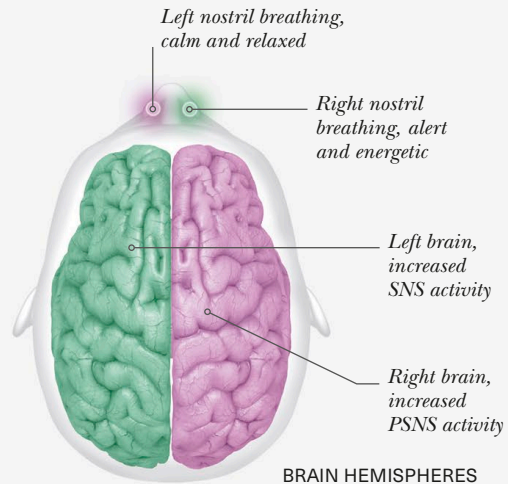
NASAL TISSUE

This image shows the right nasal passage swollen while the left is open. In this case the swelling is exacerbated by congestion.

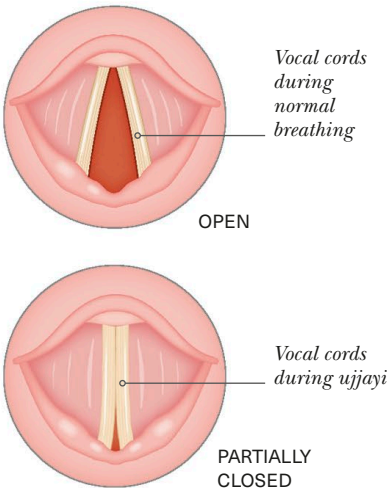


Left brain, right brain

Each half of your body is controlled by the opposite hemisphere of your brain—meaning that your left arm is controlled by the right half of your brain. The same is true of your nostrils. This may have many implications, including a slight overall increase in SNS activity when right nostril breathing and PSNS when left, although evidence is mixed.



BRAIN HEMISPHERES

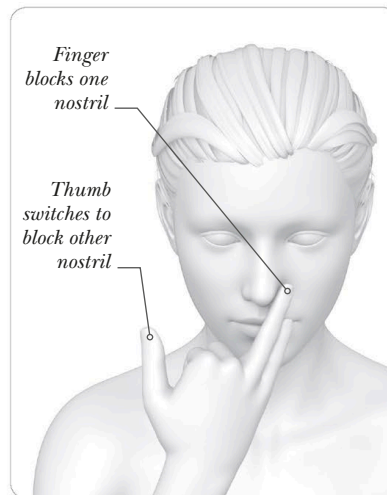


OPEN

PARTIALLY CLOSED

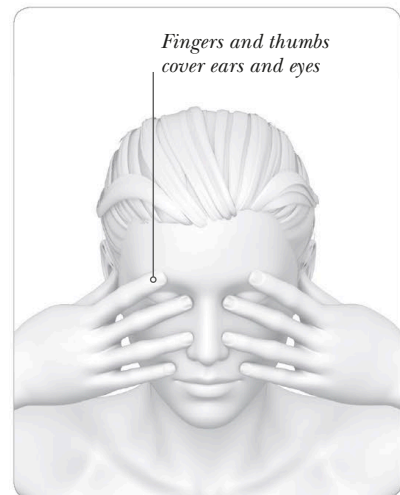
VICTORIOUS BREATH (UJJAYI)

Victorious breath involves partially constricting your vocal cords. The feeling is similar to when you whisper softly. It creates an ocean sound to give your mind a focal point.



ALTERNATE NOSTRIL BREATHING

This technique may calm the mind and body. It involves focus and activation of both sides of the brain. To practice it, just remember: exhale, inhale, and switch nostrils.



BEE BREATH (BRAHMARI)

This involves covering your eyes and ears and humming on a long exhale. Yogis used this to improve sleep. Research shows it can lower heart rate, blood pressure, and anxiety.